World War I offered a number of Eastern European countries the opportunity to escape Germanic influence and regain independence. Poland was resurrected, and two new, rather artificial states were created: Czechoslovakia and Yugoslavia. Yet, during World War I, many Slovenians, Czechs, Slovaks and Poles fought as Austrian soldiers – a duty they must have performed with very mixed feelings. Austria was increasingly a bad mother to them, favouring its German-speaking children. But the prospect of, say, Russian rule for Polish people or Italian rule for Slovenians was not particularly inspiring either.[33] From that point of view, the creation of independent national or multinational Slavic states, however imperfect, was seen as probably the best possible outcome. In the end, World War I left Germany and Austria humiliated, reduced, and perhaps, as German-speaking subjects themselves felt, misunderstood. Austrians in particular felt that they had been betrayed by the Slavs, and they did not recover for some time. The feeling of loss is not completely gone even today. In a private discussion about Kosovo in 2007, a high-ranking Austrian diplomat remarked to an embittered Serbian minister that Austria too had had to go through the process of losing part of its territory. After World War I that was certainly also the feeling of Slovenians, as Slovenian-populated south Carinthia ended up in the newly formed Republic of Austria.

But it was World War II which has had an even more dramatic and decisive impact on the living memory of the peoples of Eastern Europe. In that war, Slavs were second only to Jews in the list of those for whom the Nazis had a murderous contempt.[34] They were also second only to Jews in the numbers who fell victim to the Nazis. (In Yugoslavia, Albania and Greece, the troops of Fascist Italy also committed horrible crimes against civilian populations – a fact later obscured when the Italians switched allegiance in 1943.) This altered relationships in Eastern Europe dramatically, reducing the appeal of German culture and its role there. After World War I, Austria had to renounce its rule over large swathes of Eastern Europe and also its own idea of a Central Europe. By contrast, after World War II, Germans withdrew from Eastern Europe not only as defeated former occupying forces, but also culturally. After more than a thousand years of shared history, the Slavic and the Germanic worlds were finally separated. The Iron Curtain only reinforced this.

Local ethnic German populations in the Czech lands, in Poland, Slovenia